



# Seville Cathedral

*A vast Christian edifice built to supplant one of the Moorish treasures of Islamic Spain*

In 1172, the Almohad caliph of southern Spain ordered the building of the Great Mosque in Seville. After the city was reconquered by the Christian Castilians in 1248, it was converted into a cathedral that served until 1401, when the city leaders decided to build a new place of worship on the same site. This new cathedral, dedicated to St. Mary, was completed in 1528.

Built in Gothic style, it was covered with ornament and carving and filled with sculpture, paintings, tombs, and memorials. Two parts of the original mosque were retained: the bell tower (La Giralda) of the cathedral was built on the minaret of the Great Mosque, and the courtyard entrance was inherited from the Moors.

## ▽ MASSIVE PROPORTIONS

At 443 ft (135 m) long, 328 ft (100 m) wide, and 138 ft (42 m) high, Seville Cathedral was the biggest cathedral in Christendom and remains the largest to this day.

## LA GIRALDA

The original Islamic minaret (left) was built in 1198 to resemble the minaret of the main mosque (see p.228) in Marrakech, Morocco. After the Christian reconquest of Seville, it was converted into a bell tower for the cathedral and then extended higher in 1568.



## △ INTERESTING ADDITIONS

Shop owners have made alterations to the bridge's superstructure by adding windows and external shutters, giving it a colorful and chaotic look.

